Hunter and the Gnat were among the most modern subsonic aircraft at that time. In addition, the IAF had the French Ouragan and the Mystère, mainly based in the Western Sector, from where Ladakh was within relatively easy range. In the Eastern Sector, Ouragans, Vampires and Hunters, apart from the Alize and Sea Hawk naval aircraft were available for hitting targets in NEFA and Tibet.

Apart from Mullik, there were others who played a role in ensuring that the IAF was kept out of the conflict. H. C. Dewan, who was an air commodore in 1962, and the officer in charge of air operations, would later say: 'Everyone talks of General Bijji Kaul and his direct line to Nehru, but few realize that I was equally close to him [Nehru]. It was I who advised him not to use fighters and bombers against the Chinese. As the army got more and more bogged down in NEFA, it became quite difficult to hold Nehru back; he wanted to launch the fighters. Had he done so, it would have had disastrous consequences, which he as a non-military person needed to understand.'

When asked for the rationale behind having advised the prime minister along these lines, Dewan said: 'I flew the Hurricane in the Arakans during World War II. Our job was mainly reconnaissance and I flew hundreds of sorties. I never saw the Japanese, only some smoke from one of their camps once. Hunters, Vampires and the Canberra were faster aircraft; they would have never found the Chinese positions.' Asked if he had ever flown in NEFA, Dewan said no, but claimed that was irrelevant because the terrain in the northeast was similar. 'Besides,' he added, 'if we had used fighters, the Chinese would have retaliated and bombed our troops who were in fixed defensive positions. It would have caused havoc. I also told Nehru that they would bomb Indian cities, including Calcutta. That effectively stopped Nehru from doing anything silly!'

Within the services, Dewan alone probably didn't influence the prime minister; it was the prevailing attitude in Air HQ in 1962 that was shocking. The Chief of Air Staff, Air Marshal Aspy Engineer, simply accepted the IB assessment at face value and rejected all talk of interdiction and close air support for our ground troops. On 20 October 1962, when the Chinese attacked the Rajput positions on the Nam Ka Chu and then attacked 1/9 GR at Tsangdhar, a C-119 Fairchild Packet overflew the drop zone around noon. On returning to Tezpur, the pilots reported to Air Vice Marshal Jaswant Singh, the AOC-in-C, and told him what they had seen from the air. HQ IV